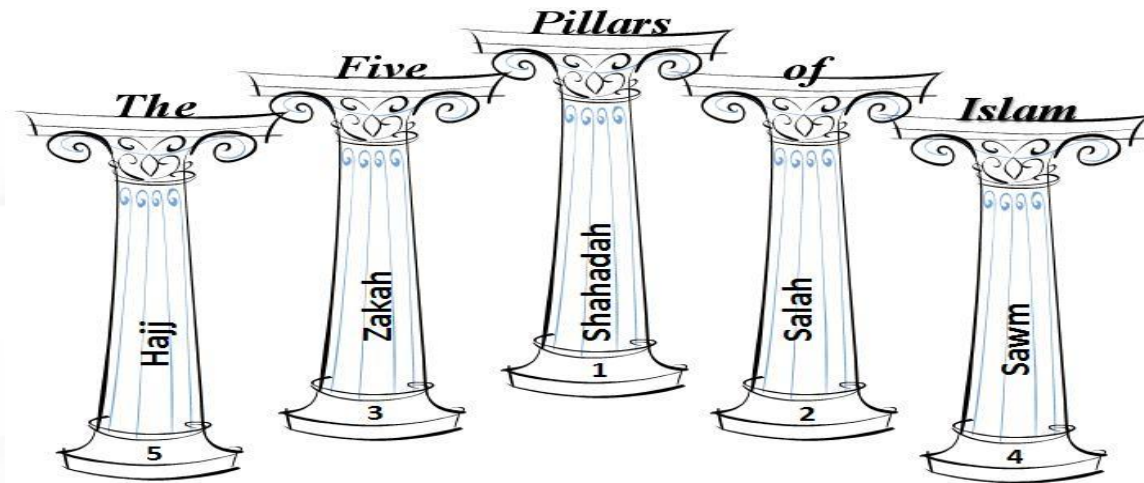


Expression of Faith in the Daily Life of a Muslim



Content

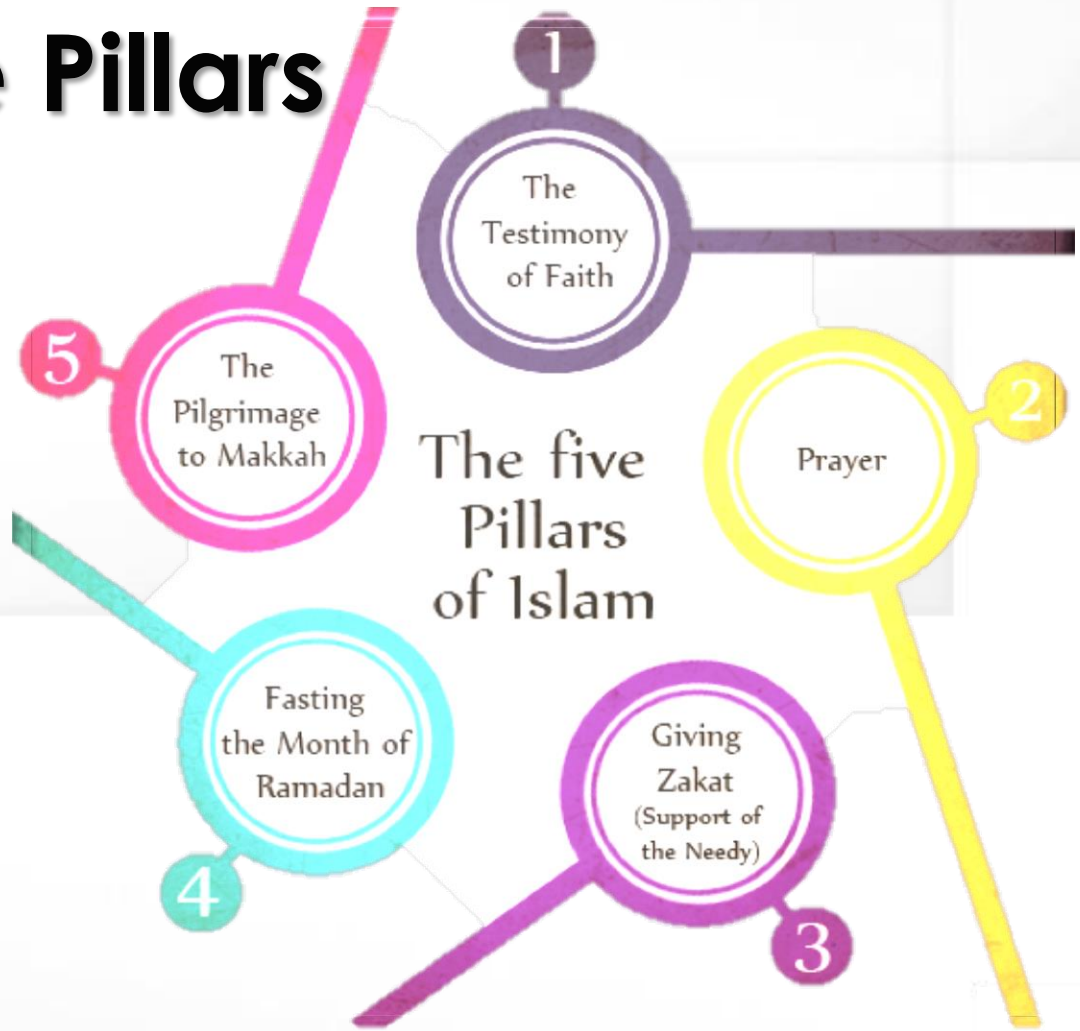
- The Five Pillars of Islam
 1. Shahadah – testifying to creed
 2. Salat – offering daily prayers
 3. Zakat – paying charity
 4. Sawm – fasting in Ramadan
 5. Hajj – making pilgrimage

Introduction

- The religion of Islam is balanced through three dimensions – *belief, practice* and *spirituality*.
- In Islam, faith is expressed in a diversity of ways to engage full human faculties.
- The five pillars of Islam provides a Muslim with a practical framework to cultivate spiritual growth.
- The five pillars range from once in a lifetime action (pilgrimage) to daily activities (daily ritual prayers)
- The five pillars address five central attachments humans have that may prevent one's spiritual development and hinder one's relationship with God.

Expression of Faith

The Five Pillars



Five Pillars in a Snapshot

	Pillar in Arabic	Pillar in English	Fundamental spiritual benefit
1	Shahadah	to testify that there is no deity but God and Muhammad is the servant and the messenger of God	Freedom from fear and incentive based earthly masters
2	Salat	to offer daily ritual prayers	Countering distractive effects of daily affairs
3	Zakat	to pay the compulsory charity	Attachment to possessions and money
4	Sawm	to fast in the month of Ramadan	Self-restraint against limiting and destructive inner impulses
5	Hajj	to make pilgrimage to the House if one is able to do so	Removal of racism and tribal attitude to religion

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of *Shahada*



Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Shahada

- Through the *shahādah*, one distances oneself from all false gods, images, forces and power bases that require submission by instilling fear or offering a benefit.
- Without this **detachment** a person is the slave of many masters such as imagined gods, power, authority, wealth, a slavishly sought goal and even one's desires.

“Have you seen the one who takes as his god his own desire?...” (Furqan, 25:43).

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Shahada

- When a person says “lā ilāha” (there is no god) – rejection of all these false deities of devotion – he/she gains true freedom.
- This makes a person equidistant to everything that is trying to control him.
- It rids the fears and the pretence of life and starts to see the reality that there is only one true God.
- After negating everything in one's mind and heart, one needs an immovable and trusted point of reference.

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Shahada

- With this realisation he says “*illā llah*” (except the God).
- “*Illā llah*” provides an eye that sees all needs, an ear that hears all prayers, whenever, wherever and however one prays.
- One now has the inner serenity and strength to face challenges that life throws at them in order that they may develop and reach their true human potential.

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Shahada

The second part of the *shahādah*, *Muhammad-ur-rasullalah* (Muhammad is God's messenger) puts one on

— “... The path of those whom You have favoured”
(Fatiha, 1:7)

- It provides a perfect human model to emulate in one's daily and spiritual life.
- It opens a channel to God through the spiritual leadership of the Prophet (pbuh).

Why Muhammad-ur-Rasulallah?

- *“We have sent you (Muḥammad) as a witness, a bearer of good news and a warner so that you (people) may believe in God and His Messenger...”*
Qur'an (48:8-9)
- Prophet Muhammad (pbuh) represents all the Messengers before him.
- He fulfils and confirms all the earlier messages.
- If the Qur'an is the theory, the life of the Prophet (pbuh) is the practical form of that theory.

Why Muhammad-ur-Rasulallah?

- The *shahādah* is like two sides of the coin
 - one side is declaring belief in one God
 - the other side is the acceptance of Prophet Muhammad (pbuh) as the role model for living the faith.

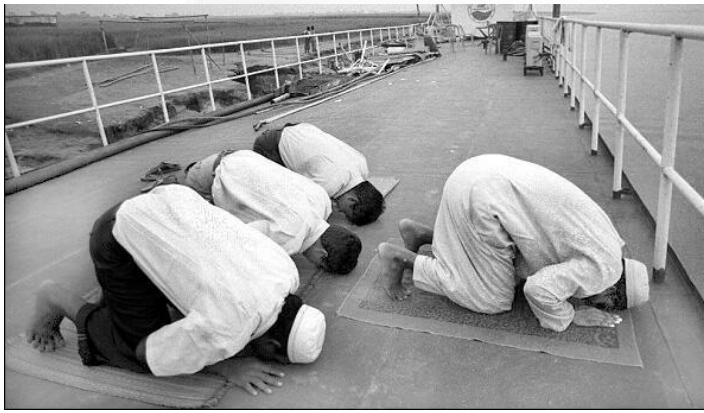
Hadith on Shahada

“Everything has its key, and the key to Paradise is the witnessing that there is no god but Allah.”

(Tabarani)

“Whoever witnesses that there is no god but Allah and that Muhammad is Allah's Messenger, Allah forbids the Fire from touching him.”

(Bukhari and Muslim)



Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Salat

Detachment From Daily Affairs

- The fundamental aim of Islamic worship is **detachment** from things and forces that hinder spiritual development.
- *Salat* **detaches** a worshipper from the daily affairs that would make us forget God.
- It is also a **detachment** from the pride of the ego.
 - Expressing one's limits and weaknesses and recognising the greatness and glory of God is the essence of *salat*.
 - Whoever sees himself as above everyone and everything else can never develop spiritually.
 - Hence, movements in the prayer break delusions of self-glory and open the door to spiritual enlightenment.

Other Benefits of Salat

Salat Facilitates Closeness to God

- The fundamental benefit of *salat* is that it enables a person to have an **intimate relationship** with God that no other single act can.
- The Prophet Muhammad (pbuh) said,
“The closest that a servant is to his Lord is when he is in prostration.” (Muslim)



Remembrance of God

- Establishing prayer means that at least five times a day Muslims are in remembrance of God.

"And perform *Salat* for My Remembrance."

(Ta-Ha, 20:14)

- Human beings are forgetful by nature and easily distracted by work and other activities, forgetting about God, our purpose in life and the Hereafter.
- Turning to prayer five times a day allows one to remember God and is reminded of one's purpose and enables us to re-focus our lives.

Social Benefits

- From a social perspective, when *salat* is performed with a group of people, it builds social cohesion and solidarity.
- Prayer groups or a congregation can be established with two or more people.
- Worshippers line up in tight and straight rows.



Social Benefits

- According to a hadith, it is important for Muslims to be standing closely together when praying:
 - "Establish your lines [straight], for indeed the angels [pray] in lines. Align your shoulders, close the gaps, yield your hands to your brothers, and do not leave any gaps for Shaytaan (Satan)."
(Ahmad, Abu Dawud)
- What the Prophet (pbuh) was referring to was the devil of superiority complex based on race, colour, wealth, status etc.

Mental Benefits

- *Salat* also has mental benefits for a worshipper.
 - Focus and meditation during prayer clears the mind of worries and information clutter that sometimes clogs our brain.
 - Breaking for prayer at key times during the day repeats this spaced repetition of meditative effect hence conditions a person to learn to detach from worry quite easily.
 - This ability to detach prevents stress and depression from development.

Physical Benefits

- Dr. Ahmed Sakr states in *Sujood (Prostration)*:
“In Islam the concept and action of prostration is very important. It is important **physically, medically, morally, spiritually and biologically.**”
- We obtain electrostatic charges which we need to eliminate.



Increasing Levels of Submission

- Physical movements for a Muslim in prayer also display progressively increasing levels of submission to God.
- In the standing-up position, with the hands together in front, the worshipper is as if saying *“my hands are tied, I am ready to submit to You my Lord”*.
- Bowing is a higher level of submission. Breaking the defense mechanisms of the ego, it is as if (s)he is saying *“I bow down only to you, I cannot see what’s in front of me. My God, I have submitted myself to You”*.

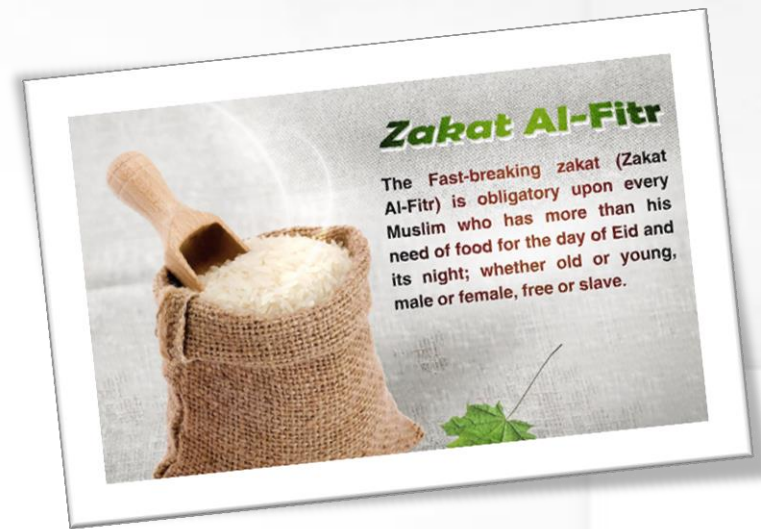
Prostration

- Prostration is the ultimate level of submission.
- It is as if the worshipper is saying, *“my God, I am lowering my head to the same level as my feet. With respect to You I have made myself as nothing. I am completely defenseless against Your Will. Even my self does not stand between You and me. I have willingly submitted my whole self to You”* .



Moral Behaviour

- A person who stands in God's presence five times a day, renewing his or her commitment to God, would surely watch what he or she did in the time between two times of *salat*.
- When a person is confronted with an opportunity to do wrong or has an immoral inclination...
- Or if the time to *salat* is close...
- In this way, a Muslim is conscientiously prevented from doing wrong and stays on the straight path (*sirat al-mustaqim*).
- The deeper the relationship with God, the more profound is its positive effect.



Spiritual Benefits of Zakat



Spiritual Benefit of Zakat

- *Zakat* detaches the worshipper from the pangs of attachment and ownership.
- Human *nafs* inherently wants to own and control unlimited amounts of wealth.
- By paying *zakat* a Muslim breaks this insatiable appetite for wealth.

Spiritual Benefit of Zakat

- Detachment from wealth can only occur if one believes that what he holds in his possession is owned by God and gives a portion of that to other less fortunate people.
- Acknowledgement that we are not the true owner of the wealth, only a temporary holder.
- The result is a spiritual transformation where the worshipper learns not to be selfish and becomes compassionate towards other fellow human beings especially when combined with fasting.
- It fosters love and compassion instead of exploitation and oppression.

Further Benefits of Zakat

Benefits for the Benefactor

- By sacrificing a portion of his/her owned wealth, a person has turned away from the natural love of riches, preferring to incline towards God.
- *Zakat* brings a person closer to God through the development of traits such as generosity.
- The love of property excessively leads to miserliness.
- Miserliness has been the sole culprit in the destruction of many civilisations.

Zakat Prevents Miserliness

- “So fear God as much as you are able and listen and obey and **spend [in the way of God]**; it is better for your selves. And whoever is **protected** from the **stinginess of his soul** - it is those who will be the **successful.**” (Taghabun, 64:16)
- “And let not those who **[greedily] withhold** what God has given them of His bounty ever think that it is better for them. Rather, it is **worse** for them. Their necks will be encircled by what they withheld on the Day of Resurrection. And to God belongs the heritage of the heavens and the earth. And God is [fully] Acquainted with what you do.” (Imran, 3:180)

Zakat is Purity

- With *zakat* the provider as well as the recipient rid themselves of potential “dirt”.
- Zakat purifies the provider from obsessive inclination towards wealth and from miserliness.
- Zakat purifies the recipient from potential hate and envy.
 - “God has decreed *zakat* compulsory to purify our accumulated wealth.” (Abu Dawud)

Zakat Grants Prosperity

- Although wealth may appear to decrease by giving zakat, it actually increases.
 - “...But whatever thing you spend [in His cause] - He will compensate it; and He is the best of providers.” (Saba, 34:39)

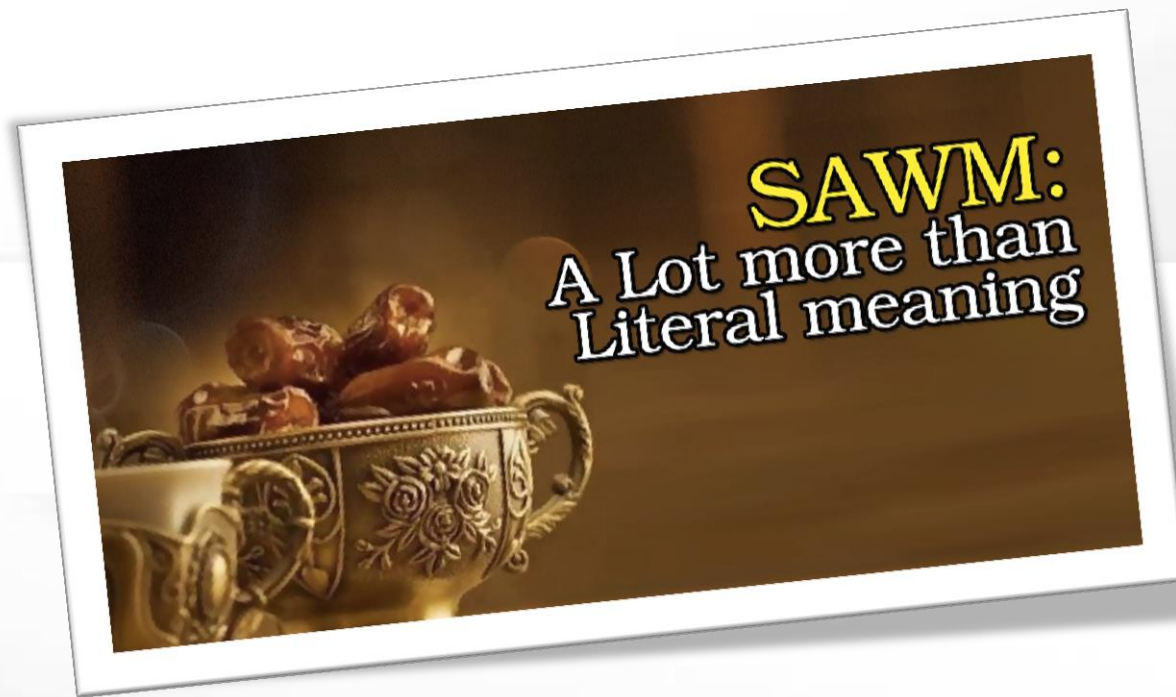
Benefits of *Zakat* for Recipients

- *Zakat* liberates from slavery to sustenance:
 - *Zakat* rescues a society from falling victim to poverty and minimising crimes such as theft.
- *Zakat* augments self esteem:
 - *Zakat* saves the poor from being thrown into total oblivion, turning them into revered people who are sought after.
 - The poor will not search for the rich but the rich will search for the poor.

Charity in History

- The history of Islam shows that there were periods when poverty was totally eradicated in Muslim lands through this culture of charity.
- So much so that they did not have any poor citizens to give alms to and directed charity to neighbouring Christian countries.
- Poor boxes were even left in the streets for people to receive charity anonymously.
- Compassion of the rich for the poor and respect of the poor for the rich underscores the social fabric of a Muslim society.

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Fasting



Detachment from Desires and Impulses

- Fasting **detaches** the worshipper from physical desires and emotional impulses.
 - Fasting is not just about staying hungry or thirsty, it is also to struggle to contain any destructive impulse of the *nafs*.
- Prophet Muhammad^{pbuh} said, *“Whoever doesn’t give up lying and acting on lies during fasting, then God has no need for him to give up food and drink.”*
- In this way, one’s absolute dependence on these desires and impulses is **detached** and transformed into a relative dependence.

Exercise Will-power and Attain Self-control

- Therefore, the fundamental spiritual benefit of fasting is to exercise the will-power and attain self-control that we need for success in every part of our lives.
- Fasting consecutively for 30 days truly sharpens the will power and makes self-control a habit such that at the end of Ramadan most people think they are still fasting.
- The benefit of the resultant razor-sharp will power extends its positive impact to every part of human life.

Other Benefits of Fasting

Fasting Reminds the *Nafs* of its Owner

- The combined effect of fasting, when performed collectively in Ramadan develop all four aspects – physical, mental, spiritual and social – of humans.
- Human *nafs* inherently thinks that it is free and unrestricted.
- The *nafs* wishes for and imagines lordship and free, arbitrary action.
- Fasting reminds the *nafs* that God is its true owner and that it does not have absolute sovereignty.
 - Thus, fasting in this way is in many respects like a key to gratitude; gratitude being man's fundamental duty."
(Nursi, 2010, p. 467)

Nafs is Reminded that it is Weak and Poor

- The *nafs* assaults the world as though it possessed a body made of steel and imagined itself to be undying and eternal.
- Fasting reminds the *nafs* that it is weak and poor and how much it is dependable to God for the provision of even the basic needs.
- This reality enables a person to face his or her Creator in supplication, ascending the individual in the transcendent ranks of spirituality.

The Physical and Spiritual Compete

- Spiritual and physical aspects of the human being compete with one another to exercise their dominance over the individual.
- If one dominates, the other subsides.
- There is a need to shift the pointer of the scale in the favour of spirituality in order to find a balanced development for the individual.
- Hunger through fasting gives the spirit a chance to get out of the physical dominance and develop.

Fasting Builds Empathy



- Through fasting, wealthy people feel what it really means to be hungry and not able to buy the food that they need to survive.
- Hence, rich need to be reminded of the emotions associated with hunger to foster help and charity.
- Fasting achieves this purpose, as it extends a welcoming bridge from rich to poor.
- This builds up a relationship between the rich and poor leading to social justice and harmony.

Bonding and Social Cohesion

- In Ramadan, Muslims get together to break fast.
- They invite each other to join in the celebration of breaking the fast.
- Rich Muslims organise dinners for the poor.
- Friends and family race to host loved ones and each other improving social cohesion and the interpersonal skills of people involved.



Bonding and Social Cohesion

- In Ramadan, Muslims run to the mosque every night for the special prayer of *Tarawih*.
- The collective exaltation, praise and glorification chanted in the mosque soften one's heart and sets the scene to mend and build broken relationships.
- Meeting new people and making new friends are the common fruits of prayers in Ramadan.
- Faces rejoice with the light of fasting during the day and praying collectively in the night.
- The end of Ramadan (*Eid*) visits further enhances old and new relationships.

Brain Functions Better on Empty Stomach

- Brain and mental faculties function more effectively over an empty stomach.
- When we eat, finite blood supply in the body shifts towards the stomach and intestine region in order to digest the food.
- The feeling of drowsiness after a heavy meal is a direct result of less blood being available for the brain.
- Since a fasting individual does not eat during the day, more blood and nutrients are available for the brain.

Health Benefits of Fasting

- It is a proven fact that most diseases, such as obesity, heart disease etc, are caused by overeating and a wrong diet.
- By fasting 30 days in a row, we acquire the habit of controlling our eating habits.
- We also learn that we do not need to eat as much as one may think to survive.
- Fewer intake of food and learning to control eating habits and the development of the will power enable a person to even lose weight and continue doing so after the Ramadan.

Fasting Rests the Digestive System

- One month of continuous fasting rests our digestive system and other related organs, especially, the liver.
- The recuperation benefit for the digestive system is only achieved if all bodily intake is stopped for a long enough period - fasting fulfills this requirement.
 - Obviously, uncontrolled eating at the break-fast time for those who miss the total point of fasting does not deliver some of these benefits.



Benefits of 2 Day Fast

- **BBC Horizon 2012: Eat, Fast and Live Longer**
- Michael Mosley has set himself a truly ambitious goal: he wants to live longer, stay younger and lose weight in the bargain. And he wants to make as few changes to his life as possible along the way.
- The 5:2 diet.
- <http://www.bbc.com/news/health-20890613>

Hajj – Making Pilgrimage



Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Hajj

- A pilgrim develops an acute sense of equality of human beings in practice rather than just theory.
- It simulates the Day of Judgment when masses gather in one place wearing only a two-pieced white garment without any stiches.
- In addition, this uniform dressing is an expression of the absolute equality of human beings.

Fundamental Spiritual Benefit of Hajj

- Muslims also realise the universality of Islam.
- It was this experience that led to the transformation of Malcolm X as he explains: “There were tens of thousands of pilgrims, from all over the world. They were of all colours, from blue-eyed blondes to black-skinned Africans. But we were all participating in the same ritual, displaying a spirit of unity and brotherhood that my experiences in America had led me to believe never could exist...You may be shocked by these words coming from me. But on this pilgrimage, what I have seen, and experienced, has forced me to rearrange much of my thought patterns previously held.”

Other Benefits of Hajj

Human Development

- Pilgrimage is a total human experience and has great benefits for a Muslim.
- The certainty of the faith of a Muslim increases through pilgrimage.
- Seeing millions of people worship one God is an immense witness that He exists.
- Visiting Ka'bah where a number of prophets are reported to be buried and Mt Hira where Qur'an first started to be revealed increases his or her attachment to the Qur'an and the Holy Prophet Muhammad^{pbuh}.

Developing Mental Strength

- Many mental skills such as determination, perseverance, patience and control of human will are exercised and developed in trying conditions of the Hajj.
- Leaving everything behind for a long period of time provides the effect of true recreation for the mind and the spirit.

Physical Benefits

- Hajj is very much a physical event.
- Going around the Ka'bah seven times and fast walk between Safa and Marwah gives Muslims ample exercise and reminds them of the need to be physically fit and also the value of good health.



Social Benefit

- In addition to removing racism, pilgrimage is the greatest social event in the world.
- A 2008 study on the longer-term effect of going to Hajj found that Muslims' communities become more open after the Hajj experience.
- Entitled *Estimating the Impact of the Hajj: Religion and Tolerance in Islam's Global Gathering*, a study conducted in conjunction with Harvard University's John F. Kennedy School of Government found that the Hajj experience promotes peaceful coexistence, equality, and harmony.

Social Benefit

- The report states that the Hajj
 - “increases belief in equality and harmony among ethnic groups and Islamic community and that Hajjis show increased belief in peace, and in equality and harmony among adherents of different religions.”

Summary

1. **Shahadah** detaches one from finite and false masters.
2. **Salat** detaches one from the affairs of the world.
3. **Fasting** detaches one from the physical desires and emotional impulses.
4. **Zakat** detaches one from the pangs of material wealth.
5. **Hajj** detaches from the load of sins and any form of superiority/arrogance.